Explaining subject knowledge in English

Practical guide for students | D11-ST

Explaining what you know involves making your reasoning visible. A short, accurate explanation with relevant evidence can communicate your understanding more clearly than a long answer with an unclear structure.

1. Identify what needs explaining

Check whether you are explaining a concept, a process, a cause or a judgement. Decide what the listener or reader needs to understand by the end.

2. Plan the main idea

Write a few keywords or sketch a simple diagram. Identify your central point and the information needed to support it. Where helpful, plan initially in a language you know well.

3. Choose a useful order

For a process, explain the stages in order. For a cause, connect the cause and result. For a judgement, state your conclusion and the reasons or evidence behind it.

4. Use accurate subject terms

Keep essential terminology, symbols and units accurate. Explain a term briefly if needed. Use clear language around technical terms rather than replacing precise concepts with vague words.

5. Connect evidence to the point

Give an example, calculation or observation and explain what it shows. Try: “This supports the conclusion because …” A result alone may not show how you reached your interpretation.

6. Check and refine the explanation

Read it aloud or explain it to a peer. Ask which connection is unclear. Correct the meaning before polishing the wording. In assessment, follow the rules about preparation and assistance.

7. Example

You explain a fall in profit: “Revenue rose from 100 to 110 million VND, but costs rose from 80 to 95 million VND. Profit therefore fell from 20 to 15 million VND because the increase in costs was greater than the increase in revenue.” The figures support the explanation and make the causal link clear.

8. Quick checklist

☐ I have a clear main point.

☐ My explanation follows a suitable order.

☐ My subject terms and figures are accurate.

☐ I explain how my evidence supports the point.

9. When to seek further support

If you understand the content but repeatedly struggle to express it, bring an example to your teacher or a language adviser. Ask whether the main difficulty is your reasoning, organisation, subject vocabulary or English expression so you can choose useful support.

10.Supporting sources

University of Newcastle Library. (n.d.). Types of paragraphs. Writing strong paragraphs. Open resource

Supports organising definitions, processes and examples in ways that connect supporting information to the main idea. Applying written structures to speech is a toolkit adaptation.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Tips for communicating with international and multilingual students. Open resource